A REALITY CHECK

This election is being seen as a direct contest between the BJP and the Congress

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

STRENGTHS

- A relatively clean image and a strong network of foot soldiers developed over the past decade
- Post the Lok Sabha election, it got the time to reorient and energise its outreach to the non-Jat OBC and Dalit voters

CHALLENGES

- Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini is still seen as his predecessor M.L. Khattar's dummy
- The party has been unable to build bridges with the agitated Jat community

CONGRESS

STRENGTHS

- A decade-long anti-incumbency against the BJP
- Firm backing of the dominant Jat community
- Has also made inroads into the ruling party's non-Jat umbrella coalition

CHALLENGES

- No consensus on Bhupinder Singh Hooda's leadership
- Other factions led by Kumari Selja, Capt. Ajay Yadav and Randeep Surjewala want say in ticket distribution

OTHER CONTENDERS

INLD-BSP

- Has some hold in north Haryana, where the alliance may slow down Jat polarisation

JJP-ASP

- The JJP's sheen is lost, but may still garner votes in its strongholds Hisar and Sirsa

AAP

- Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann is pumping resources to expand the party in north Haryana; may eat into BJP's votes in a few urban pockets

Jannayak Janta Party (JJP) have imploded, their support bases largely absorbed by the two national parties. Six years after their split, the INLD, led by former deputy prime minister and Jat stalwart Devi Lal's grandson Abhay Chautala, and the JJP, led by the latter's nephew Dushyant Chautala, together managed to secure mere 2.7 per cent of the votes in the Lok Sabha election. Soon after the EC announced the assembly election dates, seven of the JJP's 10 state legislators jumped ship and are now seeking refuge in either the BJP or the Congress.

Amid desertions, the JJP on August 27 joined hands with Lok Sabha MP Chandra Shekhar's Dalit-centric Azad Samaj Party (ASP) in an attempt to counterbalance the INLD's alliance with the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP).

But with both the INLD and the JJP at a low ebb, Hooda is confident that the Jat vote will consolidate in his favour yet again. His strategy revolves around exploiting the community's disillusionment with the BJP—stemming from the perceived sidelining of their interests ever since Khattar, a non-Jat, was appointed CM in 2014 and exacerbated by the 2016 quota agitation besides the farmers' and wrestlers' protests more recently. The controversy surrounding wrestler Vinesh Phogat has further fuelled the anti-BJP sentiment among Jats. The perception is that Vinesh, who had led the protest against alleged sexual abuse in the sport, was first wronged by the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) and then the Indian Olympic Association (IOA) failed to do enough to get her an Olympic medal after she was disqualified during the weigh-in just before her final bout in Paris. Both sports bodies are manned by officials close to the BJP. To mitigate potential damage, the Saini government announced rewards for Phogat on the lines of those for Olympic medal winners, while the Union sports ministry quickly moved to reconstitute the ad hoc committee of the IOA overseeing the WFI's operations.

The Congress, despite attempting to capitalise on the BJP's shortcomings, finds itself running parallel, uncoordinated campaigns—Hooda's 'Haryana Mange Hisab' rallies and Selja's 'Jansandesh Yatra', for instance—which have left its supporters confused. The Hooda camp is pushing for him to be declared CM candidate, while the rival faction advocates for the decision to be left to the Congress MLAs post election. A recent high-stakes meeting in Delhi saw a heated argument between Selja and state unit chief and Hooda loyalist Uday Bhan in the presence of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge. Subsequently, Selja, a Lok Sabha MP, has declared her intention to contest the assembly polls.

If there's one thing that both Hooda and Selja agree upon is that the Congress will not be allying with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) even as they had fought the Lok Sabha election together in Haryana. Amid the challenge posed by the AAP and other regional players, the Congress's efforts to present a united front and the BJP's to put its umbrella caste coalition back in order will decide who gets to sit in the chief minister's seat come October. ■